

of your kitchen. Get a cool old farm table with a nice patina and a long waist-height dresser with locking castor wheels attached to the legs. Add a couple of towel bars on each side, and you are good to go. Use an antique, top-opening soda cooler with an added stainless steel top. Kitchen islands can be phenomenally expensive to purchase from a design center. A little imagination can save you tons of cash.

3. Bulk spices

There are some incredible deals out there on large-quantity spice purchases. Since spices are often a main holdup to trying new menu items at home, indulging in a well-stocked spice pantry is a smart move for the would-be at-home gourmet.

4. Tools on the cheap

Along with slotted spoons, mixing bowls, and garlic presses, I include pots and pans in this category. One super place I've found to get decent professional-quality stainless-steel items is Ikea. Strolling antiques markets is another fun way to have an afternoon out and find old kitchen gadgets for cheap. You'll also find some with fabulous character and patina this way.

5. Industrial shelving

Industrial shelving is a prime kitchen-decorating candidate, particularly for single city-dwelling folks who are short on tools. The newer stainless steel versions come with not only the add-on wine and glass racks, but pullout drawers and add-on shelf options.

6. The corner pantry

While fantastic for large-quantity food storage, they are also handy for awkward-to-store appliances and holiday/party-serving dishes. If you can't build in a custom one due to renting or financial concerns, go with a long curtain from a rod or tension cable or a carved wooden divider screen. The items will be stylishly hidden, and imagine just being able to walk in and grab what you need off an easy-to-access industrial shelf. No more fighting with stuff in hard-to-reach cabinet corners.

7. Fewer small kitchen appliances

I recommend choosing these things judiciously. The last thing you need is to give up valuable storage space to gadgets you never use. Electric hand mixers, a good blender, and if possible